

**Gender Roles in Heterosexual Marriages and Parenthood  
in the Western United States\***

Kimberly Williams

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\* Kimberly Williams can be reached at [bkimbere@byu.edu](mailto:bkimbere@byu.edu).

## GENDER ROLES IN HETEROSEXUAL MARRIAGES AND PARENTHOOD IN THE WESTERN UNITED STATES

Gender expectations play a role in many aspects of life and society: occupational choices, household chores, social expectations regarding behavior and emotions, clothing choices, career advancement opportunities, access to healthcare, parenting styles, and how people are perceived and treated in society. Existing research approaches many of these topics broadly or is too old to encompass modern ideological views, so in regards to married heterosexual couples, there is a gap in the modern relationships between gender roles, spousal expectations, labor division, and parenting. This study explores questions such as: How do gender roles contribute to the unequal division of labor in households? What impact do they have on healthy communication and communication of expectations between spouses? How do they influence parenting styles, expectations, and burnout? Using a cluster sampling method, this research will survey roughly 840 married heterosexual couples from the Western region of the U.S. to examine these dynamics. The findings aim to provide insights into how entrenched gender norms affect family life and relationships.

Keywords: gender expectations, parenthood, heterosexual relationships, gender roles

## GENDER ROLES IN HETEROSEXUAL MARRIAGES AND PARENTHOOD IN THE WESTERN UNITED STATES

Gender roles have long shaped societal structures. Masculinity has traditionally revolved around constructs like strength, stoicism, leadership, dominance, and religious responsibilities whereas femininity has traditionally exemplified the complement constructs like nurturer, delicacy, emotional awareness, household responsibilities, and social welfare (Chen et al. 2023). There are two main spheres of gender ideologies we will be examining throughout this research: Egalitarian and Traditional. An Egalitarian gender ideology is the expectation that both men and women are equally responsible for roles in the household including income, household labor, and childcare. A Traditional gender ideology is the expectation that men and women should have separate roles in work and family life and includes the expectations of the constructs listed above. This essentially means that men are expected to be the primary breadwinner while women are expected to support their husband and family emotionally and domestically.

Both sets of expectations often fail to capture the broad spectrum of gender expression, even for those whose gender aligns with their biological sex, and fail to acknowledge that “within-gender differences are often larger than those between the genders” (Zosuls et al. 2011). Ilona Maher exemplifies this dissonance between feminine constructs and actual female expression. As a rugby player for the US team recently dubbed ‘America’s Sweetheart’ by People magazine, she challenges gender expectations by dominating traditional masculine qualities like strength and power while embracing traditional feminine qualities like delicacy and beauty. Her lived experience underscores the tension between rigid gender norms and the fluidity of actual gender expression, a dynamic that extends into the private spheres of relationships and family life.

This research examines some of the ways gender roles and ideologies are influencing individual behaviors, relationship dynamics, and family systems. This influence is particularly pronounced in the context of married heterosexual couples, where traditional views of masculinity and femininity continue to influence the division of labor, spousal interactions, and parenting approaches. As was noted in the abstract, existing research has explored gender norms broadly, often addressing their impact on workplace equality, public health, and emotional well-being (Erving, Wright, and Lara 2022; Mickelson, Claffey, and Williams 2006; Stertz and Wiese 2024; Zosuls et al. 2011); however, the private sphere of marriage remains under-explored, especially in understanding how these roles affect the nuanced dynamics between spouses and in their roles as parents.

This study aims to bridge this gap by examining the intersection of gender roles, spousal communication of expectations, labor division, and parenting among married heterosexual couples. By focusing on the interplay between these aspects of gender roles in heterosexual marriages, this research seeks to uncover how societal norms seep into family life, influencing the lived experiences of both spouses and their children. Drawing on data from roughly 840 couples in the Western United States, this study would provide insights into how traditional gender norms perpetuate inequalities within the family unit and will offer implications for fostering more equitable relationships.

## LITERATURE REVIEW

The division of labor and gender roles within marital relationships has been a critical focus in understanding family dynamics and societal expectations. Research suggests that traditional gender roles significantly shape household responsibilities, impacting both relational quality and individual well-being (Ogolsky et al. 2014). The persistence of gendered

expectations in heterosexual relationships, in spite of shifts toward egalitarian ideologies, demonstrates a lag between attitudinal and societal changes and actual behavioral practices within families (Erving et al. 2022).

#### *Gender Roles Contribution to the Unequal Division of Labor*

The inequitable distribution of household labor remains a central issue. Studies reveal that even in dual-earner households, women often shoulder a disproportionate share of domestic responsibilities (Mickleson et al. 2006; Ogolsky et al. 2014; Stertz and Wiese 2024; Daminger 2019). Discrepancies in cognitive ideals and behavioral practices regarding egalitarianism or gender equality between spouses can negatively affect marital satisfaction, with wives being particularly sensitive to such disparities (Ogolsky et al. 2014). The negative impacts of the unequal division of labor also affect men, with some studies showing that traditional gender ideologies among men are linked to physiological stress dysregulation for both spouses, underscoring the health implications of inequity in domestic roles (Seiter et al. 2022).

#### *Gender Roles Effect on Healthy Communication*

Depending on a woman's gender role attitudes—traditional vs egalitarian—that division of labor communicates differing levels of support and can be just as vital as emotional support towards marital quality (Mickelson et al 2006). Emotional support, however, is also unbalanced, as men are more likely to rely on their wives for emotional support, leading to yet higher stressors and responsibility on the wives (Mickelson et al 2006; Seiter et al. 2022). Men are also relying heavily on their wives for cognitive labor or management of household tasks (Daming 2019). This dependency on the wife to understand and communicate the needs of the household leads to decision fatigue, and a further breakdown of healthy communication between spouses (Daming 2019).

When ideologies align with behavior, especially for more traditional women, stress is ameliorated (Seiter et al. 2022). So perhaps communication of expectations could mitigate some of that imbalance, but further research is necessary.

### *Gender Roles in Parenting Styles, Expectations, and Burnout*

Parenting styles are also deeply intertwined with gender role attitudes. Research demonstrates that parents with traditional child-rearing attitudes often reinforce gendered behaviors in their children, impacting the children's social adjustment and perpetuating intergenerational gender role adherence (Chen et al 2023; Wang and Cheung 2023). Gender role attitudes affect the stress levels of stepparents as well with “stepparents and biological parents who expressed nontraditional gender views and high marital quality” being the only ones with no difference in reported parenting stress (Shapiro 2014). Other studies also show that the stress and burnout associated with parenting are exacerbated in inequitable partnerships, where one spouse, often the mother, carries a greater burden of both emotional and physical caregiving responsibilities (Stertz and Wiese 2024). Part of that inequitable labor distribution in parenting can be attributed to Maternal gatekeeping where mothers restrict fathers' involvement in child-rearing. Gatekeeping behaviors may likely be influenced by maternal attitudes toward paternal competence, which in turn shape father involvement (Fagan and Barnett 2003). This dynamic reflects the entrenched societal norms assigning caregiving primarily to women and undermining collaborative and egalitarian parenting approaches.

### *Gender Roles Impact on Family Life and Relationships*

These findings underscore the pervasive influence of traditional gender roles on family life and the changes that continue to occur because of a more egalitarian point of view. While egalitarian ideals are associated with better marital quality and reduced stress, achieving true

behavioral equity requires systemic shifts in cultural norms, policy support for work-life balance, and deliberate efforts by couples to renegotiate expectations and responsibilities (Stertz & Wiese 2024; Ogolsky et al. 2014).

## PROPOSED RESEARCH

In an effort to study the relationships between gender roles and their effects on married heterosexual couples, new research must come about. Based on the review of the scholarly literature and motivated by the unanswered questions and unaddressed issues, the following is the proposal for how the research may be accomplished.

### *Research Questions*

To focus our research and align expectations, these will be the guiding questions for the research: How do gender roles contribute to the unequal division of labor in households? What impact do gender roles have on healthy communication and sexuality between spouses? How do gender roles influence parenting styles, expectations, and burnout?

### *Methods: Addressing the Questions*

In order to address the research questions, a survey will be administered to both spouses asking Quantitative questions such as: ‘How many hours per week do you spend on housework?’, ‘How many hours per week does your spouse spend on housework?’, ‘How closely does your gender expression align with traditional gender expectations (masculinity: strength, stoicism, leadership, etc, femininity: nurturer, emotional awareness, social welfare, etc)? Very Close, Slightly Close, Neither matches my gender expression, Both match my gender expression, Slightly Closer to opposite gender expressions, Very Close to opposite gender expression’, ‘How closely does your spouse’s gender expression align...’, ‘On a scale of 1 to 10 how important is affirming traditional gender roles for your children (or future children) to you

(e.g. expectations about daughters with household chores and propriety and sons with sport proficiency and confidence)?’, etc. And Qualitative questions such as: ‘How would you describe traditional gender roles and expectations?’, ‘What key words would you use to describe the current state of your marriage?’, ‘What were some of the “dream jobs” you had as a child?’, etc. We can use triangulation of the quantitative and qualitative methods to arrive at a clearer picture of the actual state of each couples marriage by studying the quantitative methods through comparing average responses to other couples average responses and perform a paired t-test with spouses as pair, and by studying the qualitative methods through observing patterns in the responses and gaining insight into how further research should be focused.

#### *Methods: Sampling*

The target population is married heterosexual couples in the generally known Western region of the United States (also as defined by the federal government): Alaska, Arizona, California, Hawaii, Idaho, Montana, Nevada, New Mexico, Oregon, Utah, Washington, and Wyoming. The sampling method would be to use cluster sampling to randomly sample 10 couples from 7 counties from each of the 12 states in the Western region. Which would give us a sample of  $N = 840$  married heterosexual couples (before accounting for non-response bias), and obtain responses through survey data. To obtain the 7 randomly selected counties, unique numbers will be assigned to a list of each county in alphabetical order, then using a random number generator, 7 cities attached to the random numbers generated will be our clusters. To obtain the 10 couples, acquire a list of marriage records of living individuals from the county clerk or county archive of vital records, assign unique numbers, and use a random number generator to get 10 couples from the sampling frame.

#### *Methods: Data Collection*



The strategy to collect data from our sample would involve multiple forms of contact. As many people no longer answer phone calls or read emails unless the contactor is familiar, we would attempt to use multiple forms of contact to allow the individuals to become familiar with our attempt, in an effort to mitigate non-response bias. The first attempt would be to call and leave a voicemail followed by an email with details about the study. The second attempt would be a second and final call with voicemail along with a mail-in version of the survey. We will reevaluate sampling methods if all attempts at contact fail, weigh the given responses accordingly, or change our sampling method to a cluster/convenience sample mix in selected counties as a last resort. If contact successfully occurs, the survey will be administered in whichever method is preferred by the subject: email or a physical mailed copy.

#### *Methods: Data Analysis*

Once the data is collected, we will use standard qualitative approaches to analyze the non-numerical data to identify themes and patterns, and use standard quantitative approaches to analyze the numerical data to find statistically significant associations, correlations, and establish evidence for potential causal relationships. This mixed-methods approach will provide a comprehensive understanding of how gender roles impact the dynamics of heterosexual marriages and parenting.

#### *Quantitative Data Analysis*

For the numerical data, several statistical analyses will be conducted. A paired t-test will compare spouses' perceptions of household labor division and alignment with traditional or egalitarian gender roles. This will help identify any significant differences between self-reported and partner-reported contributions, potentially revealing blind spots or areas of disagreement within couples. For example, a spouse may overestimate their own contributions relative to their

partner's perspective, a pattern documented in prior research on domestic labor perceptions (Mickelson et al. 2006).

We will also use multiple linear regression analysis to explore the relationships between gender role alignment, household labor division, and marital satisfaction. Predictor variables may include self-reported alignment with traditional gender norms, hours spent on housework, and emotional support metrics. The response variable, marital satisfaction, will be measured using a validated survey scale. By examining interaction effects, such as whether the impact of traditional gender roles differs between men and women, we can identify nuanced dynamics in these relationships.

Cluster analysis will also be performed to identify subgroups within the sample, such as couples who exhibit high egalitarianism versus those who adhere to traditional roles. This can provide insights into whether these clusters correlate with different levels of marital satisfaction, communication quality, or parenting stress.

The regional focus of the study can also provide insights as this is a cluster sampling method. Conducting comparisons across counties and states can aid in identifying geographic trends. For example, we may examine whether couples in urban counties report more egalitarian dynamics compared to those in rural counties, analyze the correlation between state political leanings and most common gender ideologies, or determine the ranking of the states marital satisfaction rates. Such analyses can highlight the influence of environmental and cultural factors on the perpetuation or erosion of traditional gender roles.

### *Qualitative Data Analysis*

The qualitative data from open-ended survey questions will be analyzed thematically using a coding framework derived from the literature review and exploratory readings of the

responses. Initial coding will identify recurring themes, such as “perceptions of fairness in labor division,” “conflicts over traditional roles,” and “gatekeeping behaviors in parenting.” A second round of axial coding will focus on the relationships between these themes, such as how perceptions of fairness influence marital quality or how gatekeeping behaviors relate to parenting stress. We will also use word frequency analysis to identify common terms and phrases associated with respondents’ definitions of traditional versus egalitarian roles.

### *Combining Approaches*

To triangulate the findings, we will compare themes from the qualitative responses with statistical patterns observed in the quantitative data. For instance, if couples who score high on egalitarian metrics report lower stress in the quantitative analysis, we will examine qualitative responses to understand the contextual factors supporting these outcomes. This integration of methods will strengthen the validity of the findings and provide a richer interpretation of the data.

### *Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research*

The research being proposed is just one step toward understanding the profound impact of gender roles on individuals and their families, and will have many limitations. Ensuring that the sample is representative and mitigating the effects of non-response bias will likely be the largest challenge. Also, although many subjects are covered in this proposed research, many topics have yet to be explored. Future studies should explore additional dimensions such as: how shifting norms impact diverse family structures; explore the effect on different regions, countries, and cultures; the ways external factors like workplace policies shape household dynamics; or how homosexual couples wrangle gender norms in household responsibilities. Only through continued inquiry can we challenge outdated constructs, mitigate the harmful effects of

misaligned expectations, contribute meaningful insights to improve the homelife of as many people as this research may reach, as well as inform policy recommendations on parental leave or workplace support for gender equity.

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## APPENDIX: JOURNAL IMPACT FACTORS

Sex Roles: [3.0](#)

Family Relations: [1.7](#)

Family Process: [2.6](#)

Humanities & Social Sciences Communications: [3.7](#)

Journal of Marriage and Family: [2.7](#)

Journal of Family Issues: [1.6](#)

American Sociological Review: [7.1](#)

## APPENDIX: SUMMARY OF CHANGES

1. The reviewer requested a label change for the abstract. As no reasoning was given by the reviewer and no format was specified for the paper, the template from Tri-College Libraries Research Guides of ASA format will continue to be followed.
2. The reviewer pointed out odd wording in the abstract. Changed wording to “or is too old to encompass modern ideological views”.
3. Again, the reviewer noted a style choice for the introduction title, but the chosen format specified the style and will continue to be followed.
4. Reviewer noted the lack of “communication” in the list of things the proposal will examine, so it was added.
5. The reviewer suggested a paragraph break at the end of the introduction. Paragraph break added.
6. The reviewer suggested another source that could be added to strengthen the Literature Review, and it was a very relevant source, so it was added.
7. The reviewer noted a lack of clear conceptualization for traditional and egalitarian, so the clarification was added to the introduction.
8. The reviewer noted an imbalance in the paragraph about communication in the literature review, so more context about cognitive labor was added. A suggestion about changing one of the research questions was also included, and is appreciated, but will not be changed at this time.
9. The reviewer again suggested more conceptualization, and it was added.
10. The reviewer expressed interest in a clarification of survey administration. It was added.



11. The reviewer suggested adding limitations. The conclusion paragraph was changed to a commentary about limitations and future research.